

PENNSYLVANIA OWNER-BUILDER PERMIT KIT

Find your code official · Pass five inspections · Earn the certificate

Project Address: _____

Municipality (Twp / Boro / City): _____

County: _____

Plan Review & Inspections by: _____

Sewage Enforcement Officer: _____

Owner-Builder: _____

Permit Application Date: _____

In a municipality that opted out, nobody assigns you an inspector — hiring one is your job, and the house still needs all five. Read PA.1 first.

Every Pennsylvania statute, regulation and threshold in this kit is cited on the page it appears on — verified September 2026.

BUILD YOUR HOUSE

build-your-house.com

First Edition — 2026

How to Use This Kit

Five working documents, from finding out who inspects your house to the certificate of occupancy that lets you move into it.

Pennsylvania is the state where the usual first question — *does the code apply out here?* — has a flat answer that almost every guide gets backwards. It does. The Uniform Construction Code applies to “the construction, alteration, repair and occupancy of **all buildings in this Commonwealth**” (35 P.S. § 7210.104(a)), and five inspections are required on every one- and two-family dwelling in it.

What Pennsylvania actually varies is **who shows up**. A municipality may hire its own code official, retain a private agency, share one with the next township, or contract with another municipality — or it may elect not to administer the code at all. That last case is the one nobody explains properly: the code does not switch off, the inspections do not go away, and the job of **finding and paying a certified third-party agency moves onto you**, the permit applicant, by name, in the statute.

That single fact reorganizes the whole build. It changes who you call first, what your lender is sent at the end, who your appeal goes to, and what happens if you simply never hire anybody — which is legal to do right up until you try to sell, insure or finance the house. **PA.1 works through it** in the order the decisions actually arrive.

WHAT IS IN THE KIT

The five documents

	Document	What it does for you
PA.1	Who Inspects Your House	Whether the UCC reaches your project at all, the six ways a municipality can handle enforcement, and what to do in each. Also the exclusions that are genuinely outside the code — including the recreational cabin, which has a seven-part test. Read this first.
PA.2	Permit Application Checklist	What to file, the review clock and how to cut it from fifteen days to five, and the Pennsylvania amendments that change what you build — stairs, wall bracing, floor membranes, the energy tables and the receptacles the Commonwealth struck out.
PA.3	Inspection Sequence	The five inspections the statute names, in order, with the rule that the final one cannot pass until the other four have. Plus the certificate of occupancy, the appeal that is granted by default if the board sleeps, and a log.
PA.4	Where to File Directory	How to establish which of Pennsylvania's 2,500-odd municipalities holds your parcel and how it handles the code, the offices that are not the building department, and a page to write down every one you confirmed.

The five documents

	Document	What it does for you
PA.5	Forms & Documents Index	Each document you will meet: what it is, when it is due, and which office it comes from — including the ones that arrive only because you are your own builder.

HOW TO USE IT

- **Start with PA.1, and settle the enforcement question before you spend anything.** One call to the municipal office answers it. Whether the answer is “we have a code official,” “we use an agency,” or “we opted out” changes who you are dealing with for the next year.
- **Work PA.2 with a pen, early.** The item that surprises Pennsylvania owner-builders is not a fee — it is that several of the rules in the printed code book on your desk have been struck out or replaced by the Commonwealth, and one of them, wall bracing, was rolled back to an edition published in 2006. Building to the book and failing the framing inspection is an expensive way to learn that.
- **If your municipality opted out, hire the agency before you break ground** — not when you are ready for the first inspection. The agency reviews the plans as well as inspecting the work, and it has no obligation to take you on.
- **Keep PA.3 on the job** and record every inspection as it happens, with the date and the result. In an opt-out municipality that log may be the only continuous record anyone holds, because the agency you hired is a private company and the township never sees the file until the end.

How these facts were checked — and what this is not

Every Pennsylvania claim here was read against its primary source in September 2026 — the Pennsylvania Construction Code Act and the other statutes at legis.state.pa.us, and 34 Pa. Code and 25 Pa. Code at pacodeandbulletin.gov — and is cited where it appears. Where a number genuinely varies by municipality, the kit says so and gives you a line to write what you confirmed rather than printing a guess. Not legal advice.